

are megastores like Tata Croma and Reliance Digital. Although malls are a convenient place to check out HDTVs, they aren't always the best place to buy one. For example, if you're sure you want a particular model from say Samsung, (for example), you may get a better price in a Samsung showroom. Obviously, such showrooms are dealers, so they will not have as wide a choice, but their prices should be competitive. So you might want to window shop in a Tata Croma and shop in a smaller electronics showroom if you get my drift.



LG LG80FR

I've also seen many people deciding what to buy in a mall based on the display quality of the units being showcased. I warn against this – all the HDTVs in such large malls are usually set up by non-professionals and hooked up to DVD players or cable connections via connects and cabling of sub-standard quality. An even bigger problem is that the display has probably *not* been calibrated or optimised for the picture it is displaying. When we test such HDTVs, one of the first things we do is ensure identical lighting conditions and other test conditions, down to the cables used and the other test equipment. After all, judging visual quality is 100 per cent subjective and rarely do two peoples opinions converge. I've often come across people in malls frowning at the seemingly washed out picture quality of a TV, only to discover myself, that the brightness level was set at 100 per cent and the display was facing a fluorescent bulb. Another time, two adjacent LG displays, one 32-inch and the other 42-inch, appeared to give very different results. While the image on the smaller TV appeared neutral, the larger one seemed to be oversaturated and the colours appeared to be artificially vivid. Upon asking the attendant what the problem was, the person started fiddling around with the brightness and contrast settings to no avail. After a minute of watching him try everything from switching inputs, to shutting down the display and turning it back on I asked for the remote and had a look. It seemed the problem was as simple as the programmed mode – on one it was set to vivid and on the other it was set at cinema. Once both displays we're identically set, the picture quality was very similar. The guy thanked me, evidently grateful that I hadn't created a fuss but discretely called him over. Take these experiences seriously, many people, not